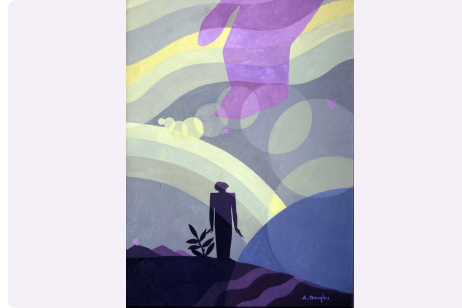


Red Level: Go Deeper

Name: _____ Date: _____ Period: _____

Critical Frame: Art historian Amy Helene Kirschke argues that Aaron Douglas "created a visual language for a people." Every formal choice Douglas made was both aesthetic and political. Analyse three works using the five technique dimensions, then write a critical interpretation of what his visual choices argue about Black identity and history.

ACTIVITY 1: THREE-WORK FORMAL ANALYSIS*Song of the Towers, 1934**The Creation, c.1935**Harriet Tubman, 2011*

Dimension	Song of the Towers	The Creation	Harriet Tubman
Silhouette use			
Circle / light			
Colour palette + meaning			
African influence			
Narrative / argument			

Red Level: Go Deeper**ACTIVITY 2: CRITICAL INTERPRETATION****What Does Douglas Argue?**

Write a two-paragraph critical interpretation. Paragraph 1: What visual argument does Douglas make about Black history and identity across all three works? Paragraph 2: How do his formal choices (silhouette, circle, colour, geometry) make that argument more powerful than if he had painted realistically?

ACTIVITY 3: THE COLLABORATION

Douglas and Langston Hughes worked together closely — Douglas illustrated Hughes's books and magazines. Look at this Douglas image and the Hughes poem "The Negro Speaks of Rivers" (1921). What visual and verbal techniques do they share? What does each medium do that the other cannot?



Aaron Douglas — untitled, c.1930s. Note the concentric circles, silhouettes, and African imagery.

Mini Museum Deep Dive

Douglas trained in European techniques but deliberately departed from them. Research *Aspects of Negro Life* (1934) — the four-panel mural at the Schomburg Center in Harlem. How does the narrative across four panels function differently from a single painting? What does sequence add to the argument?

minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

Critical Question: Douglas removed facial features from his figures, making them archetypes rather than individuals. Some critics argued this dehumanised his subjects. How would you defend Douglas's choice against this criticism?